

bill has bright
sheath in summer

webbed feet

Atlantic puffin

Fratercula arctica

Puffins are probably one of the most easily recognizable birds—particularly the Atlantic puffin, with its large, brightly colored, triangular bill. They are small, upright seabirds that come to land only to breed. They are less like penguins than their cousins the guillemots, which stand upright on their heels and tails, their legs set right at the back of the body. Puffins have more centrally placed legs and walk more easily.

Temporary finery

In spring, the puffin's bill sheath expands and gains its bright red summer colors. The number of yellow grooves in the red tip indicate the bird's age. By fall, the sheath is shed and the bill becomes smaller and duller for the winter. Without the need for the visual communication required at a breeding colony, the bill transforms into a practical tool for catching fish. Puffins dive deep for food, "flying" through the water with ease. They usually catch several small fish in a single dive, especially when collecting food for their chick.

Cliff-top colonies

Puffin colonies, some consisting of hundreds of thousands of pairs, spread over clifftop slopes and broken, rocky screes. Puffins from a colony often fly out over the sea in magnificent, swirling flocks to keep predators at bay and reduce the chances of individual puffins being killed. On land, they are noisy, at times aggressive, showing off their bright beaks and feet.

Puffins have a lifespan of 10–20 years, and they will often return to the same nest burrow year after year. If a new breeding pair cannot find an old burrow to occupy, they dig one with their feet, kicking out the soft soil until it is about 3ft (1m) deep. The female lays a single egg, which is held by either parent against a bare, hot "brood patch" under one drooped wing. The chick hatches after 36–45 days and both parents feed it for up to 60 days. The young puffin is then left alone and stands at the end of the burrow for several nights until it flies off to the sea. The synchronized timing of breeding leads to almost all adults leaving the colony together, so busy colonies become silent within a few days.

The **record number of sand eels** seen in an **Atlantic puffin's bill** is **83**



◀ UP IN THE AIR

Atlantic puffins are capable of flapping their wings 400 times a minute, giving them a top speed of 55 mph (90 km/h).

△ PUFFIN COLONY

Adults fly up to 60 miles (100 km) out to sea in search of fish for their chick, usually returning to the colony in groups.